

SAXO BANK AND THOUGHTWORKS: ENABLING DATA DEMOCRATIZATION AT A GLOBAL INVESTMENT BANK

Saxo Bank partnered with Thoughtworks to leverage business data for enhanced customer experience

Today, data is ubiquitous. More than ever before, business users and functions want to support their decision making with data. However, organizations are still struggling to empower their employees to make the most informed and data led decisions. Centralized data teams and platforms fail to keep up with the need for varied context, speed and accuracy.

Data Mesh serves as a solution to these problems. Briefly put, Data Mesh applies the time tested principles and the learnings from building comprehensive, internet-scale solutions to unlock the true potential of enterprise data.

Here's Thoughtworks' four principles of Data Mesh

Domain ownership: Data owned by the data producers in a specific domain reduces the contextual gap for consumers.

Data as a product: Applying product thinking for data assets. Bringing DATSIS principles creates trust in data.

Self-serve data platforms: Empowering data producers and business users with automation and self-serve platforms to become data owners.

Federated computational governance: Computational data governance policies can be federated without centralized authority.

Success story of Thoughtworks' partnership with Saxo Bank

Saxo bank is a world-leading provider of online trading

"Saxo has been on a journey towards a federated data architecture since late 2018, during which time we have leaned heavily on Thoughtworks' leadership in the emerging space of 'data mesh'. When it came to validating and shaping our thinking about governance of the mesh, Thoughtworks was top of our list as a consulting partner. Over the course of a 15-month engagement, the Thoughtworks team have proved themselves to be a key collaborator in not only shaping but executing on our vision."

Graham Stirling, Head of Data Platforms at Saxo Bank

and investment. Providing access to over 40,000 financial products and industry insight, Saxo connects traders, investors and partners to global financial markets since 1992.

The bank has long recognized the importance of data driven decisions and the continuous improvement of client experience – 'Saxo Experience' – for its more than 800,000 clients.

Building on their investment in a stream-first data platform, they needed:–

- Visibility of data availability – meaning, quality and ownership
- Trust in the provenance and quality of data

Partnering with Thoughtworks, Saxo Bank embarked on a journey to build the Data Workbench platform that would enable domain teams to explore and consume data products.

Saxo Bank wanted to adopt principles of data mesh to give data ownership to domain teams, bring transparency via product thinking, and enable federated

data governance. Thoughtworks performed a rigorous evaluation of commercial, and open-source, tools to meet the business goals of Saxo. The global technology consultancy integrated the chosen tools into the Saxo ecosystem and enabled domain onboarding process.

Both Thoughtworks and Saxo Bank co-chartered the vision-driven data governance roadmap for the future. Then, using the data mesh approach Thoughtworks created a new business glossary of unified definitions for business terms across the organization to eliminate dependencies and confusion. This enabled the easy search of data assets and their origins, building trust in data via DATSIS principles and improving governance.

Thoughtworks co-defined key personas, created the data catalog and data quality framework. Discoverability was enabled with a comprehensive view of data assets and products.

Thoughtworks delivered a minimum viable product (MVP) for data lineage and business glossary in just 5 months, with further iterations delivered over the course of the next 6 months in close collaboration with the Saxo team.

Overall, the data workbench created trust in data leading to reduced onboarding time for banks, optimizing operating cost by containing the size of operating team to miniscule, and reducing probabilities of non-compliance by creating trust in data.

"As a digital native disruptor, we have been able to effectively partner with Saxo Bank and move them closer to realizing their ambitious vision of monetizing data through a whitelisted open banking platform. We leveraged our expertise of building platform ecosystems and data-driven business models by adopting data mesh principles to address their challenges."

Sudhir Tiwari, Managing Director for Thoughtworks in India.